

[Return to Search](#)

Religion, morality, and the person

Author(S): Fortes, Meyer, Goody, Jack

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 222

Culture (OWC): [Tallensi \(FE11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1934-1937; 1971

Coverage Date: 1930-1971

Place Coverage: Tongo Village, Ghana

Section Title(S): III • IV

Tallensi consider the crowning glory, indeed the only worthwhile object of life, to be assurance of leaving descendants, ideally in the male line, to perpetuate the memory and above all to fulfil the ritual tasks of ancestor worship. To have lived successfully one must die with the hope of achieving ancestorhood and that is possible only if one leaves male descendants. That is why, Tallensi say, one desires sons but longs for grandsons. As in many tribal societies, and consistently with this point of view, the restraint that is customary between parents and children is counterbalanced by a classical joking relationship between grandparents and grandchildren.

185
[Cultural Goals](#)

603
[Grandparents And Grandchildren](#)

829
[Ethnosociology](#)

844
[Childbirth](#)

IV

The status of the first born, female as well as male, is crucial in this family system. It is dramatized in a series of eloquent customary practices and beliefs.

784
[Avoidance And Taboo](#)

844
[Childbirth](#)

861
[Techniques Of Socialization](#)

First borns are designated by a special term. From the age of about five or six a first born son may not eat out of the same [223](#) dish as his father, whereas his younger siblings commonly do. Tallensi say that if a father and his first born son eat out of the same dish the son might accidentally scratch the father's hand, and this would cause the death of one of them. The same accident, with a younger son, is not dangerous. I have protested to Tallensi friends that these beliefs are patently illogical. They answer that this may appear to be the case, but it is a taboo laid down by their ancestors and is not to be trifled with. It is part of a whole

configuration of prohibitions and injunctions. Any first born will rattle them off. Said Badiwona, aged about six: 'I share my mother's dish of food. I never eat with my father. If I did I might die of a wasting disease. It's because I'm his first born. We first born sons may not eat chicken, we may not look into our father's granary, we may not wear his cap or his tunic or carry his quiver or use his bow.' Always, there is the implicit contrast with younger siblings and the certainty that breach of these taboos would lead to some vaguely apprehended disaster. I never came across or heard of a case of deliberate flouting of any of these rules. The 'moral regulator' (to quote Miller) inculcated from earliest childhood and backed by the whole system of social arrangements and of religious beliefs, works irresistibly.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)